Furuno DRS4D-NXT Radar

Wire Protocol & System Technical Manual

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A complete technical reference for the Furuno DRS4D-NXT marine radar system, covering the wire protocol, echo data encoding, system architecture, web interface, and development guide.

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Part I

Overview & Usage

1 Introduction

This document is the complete technical reference for the Furuno DRS4D-NXT marine radar system as interfaced through the `furuno-server` Rust application. It covers radar operation via a browser-based web interface, the internal software architecture, echo data encoding and decoding, and the full wire protocol. The intended audiences are new users learning to operate the system, contributors modifying the codebase, and developers building their own applications on top of the radar hardware.

1.1 Hardware Overview

The Furuno DRS4D-NXT is a solid-state Doppler marine radar operating in the X-band at 9.41 GHz. The scanner unit contains the antenna, transmitter, and receiver in a single sealed radome enclosure. It connects to a host processor—in this deployment, a Raspberry Pi—via a standard Ethernet cable. The scanner is assigned a fixed IP address of `172.31.3.226` on a `172.31.0.0/16` subnet.

The radar transmits at up to 25 watts using solid-state amplification rather than a traditional magnetron, which eliminates warm-up time and provides consistent performance across the operating temperature range. The antenna rotates at either 24 or 48 RPM depending on the selected speed mode. Echo data is delivered as radial spokes, with 8192 unique azimuth positions per full rotation and up to 868 range bins per spoke. The system supports six pulse width settings (S1, S2, M1, M2, M3, L), 18 range scales from 1/16 NM to 48 NM, and built-in Doppler target discrimination.

1.2 Software Components

The system consists of three software components.

furuno-server is a Rust binary that implements the complete Furuno wire protocol from scratch. It handles network discovery, authentication, control commands, echo data reception and decoding across four encoding types, PPI (Plan Position Indicator) rendering, and serves a web interface for browser-based operation. The application is built with Axum 0.7 for the HTTP server and Tokio for the async runtime. All radar communication—TCP control, UDP multicast echo reception, and subnet management—is handled natively without any Furuno proprietary libraries.

The *web interface* is a set of static HTML, CSS, and JavaScript files served by the Rust application. It provides four pages: a controls dashboard for quick radar operation, a full-screen PPI display with history compositing, a detailed settings panel, and a system status view. The interface communicates with the server through a REST API and polls for updated radar images at 500 ms intervals.

The *documentation* consists of this technical manual and inline source code comments. The manual is maintained as a single self-contained LaTeX file with all diagrams rendered via TikZ.

1.3 Reverse Engineering Context

All protocol knowledge in this document was obtained through reverse engineering. The primary source was the proprietary Furuno shared library `libNAVNETDLL.so`, which was analyzed through symbol table inspection, function call tracing, and behavioral observation. Live packet captures between the library and the radar hardware provided ground truth for the authentication handshake, control message format, and echo data encoding. The Rust implementation in `furuno-server` was built incrementally by reproducing each protocol phase and validating against the radar's actual responses.

The original C++ application that used `libNAVNETDLL.so` directly served as a reference implementation during this process. Command IDs, parameter ranges, and encoding schemes documented here have been verified against both the disassembled library and live radar behavior. Where the proprietary library's behavior was ambiguous or undocumented, the values in this manual reflect what was observed to work reliably in practice.

2 Quick Start & Installation

2.1 Prerequisites

The Rust toolchain is required to build the application. Install it via `rustup` if it is not already present.

```
curl --proto '=https' --tlsv1.2 -sSf https://sh.rustup.rs | sh
source ~/.cargo/env
```

The application builds and runs on Linux (x86_64 and aarch64), macOS, and Windows. The primary deployment target is a Raspberry Pi running Debian, connected to the radar via its Ethernet port. No external C libraries or Furuno SDKs are required.

2.2 Building

From the repository root, build the release binary.

```
cd furuno-server
cargo build --release
```

The compiled binary is located at `furuno-server/target/release/furuno-server`. A release build is recommended for deployment as it enables compiler optimizations that significantly improve echo decoding and PPI rendering throughput.

2.3 First Run

Start the web server with the `web` mode.

```
cargo run --release -- web
```

The web interface is then available at `http://localhost:8080` in any browser. On startup, the application attempts to discover the radar automatically (see below). If the radar is not reachable, the web server starts anyway and serves a degraded interface. The `/reconnect` endpoint can be used to retry the connection later.

2.4 Auto-Discovery

The application resolves the radar and host IP addresses through a three-stage fallback process.

First, it checks for explicit command-line flags. If `--radar-ip` is provided, that address is used directly. The `--host-ip` flag is optional; if omitted, the application determines a suitable host address on the radar's subnet automatically.

```
cargo run --release -- --radar-ip 172.31.3.226 web
```

Second, if no flags are provided, the application broadcasts UDP discovery beacons on port 10010 across all detected network interfaces and listens for 3 seconds. If the radar responds, both the radar and host addresses are extracted from the response.

Third, if discovery fails, the application falls back to the default addresses: `172.31.3.226` for the radar and `172.31.1.100` for the host. If the host does not already have an interface on the `172.31.0.0/16` subnet, a secondary IP alias is added to the physical Ethernet interface automatically. On Linux this uses `ip addr add`; on macOS, `ifconfig alias`.

3 CLI Modes

3.1 General Syntax

The application accepts optional IP flags followed by a mode name and mode-specific arguments.

```
furuno-server [--radar-ip IP] [--host-ip IP] <mode> [args...]
```

The two user-facing modes are `web` and `discover`. Additional developer-oriented modes (`handshake`, `tx-on`, `tx-off`, `echo`, `full`, `render-live`, `dump-raw`, `test-commands`, `validate`) are documented in §13. If no mode is given, the application defaults to `handshake`.

3.2 Web Server Mode

The `web` mode starts the HTTP server and is the primary way to operate the radar.

```
furuno-server web [port] [webdir]
```

The optional `port` argument sets the listening port (default 8080). The optional `webdir` argument specifies the path to the static web files (default `../web` relative to the binary). On startup, the server attempts to authenticate with the radar and initialize the control channel. If the radar is unreachable, the server starts anyway with degraded functionality—the PPI display shows a blank image and setting changes are queued until a connection is established via the `/reconnect` endpoint.

3.3 Discover Mode

The `discover` mode broadcasts UDP beacons on port 10010 across all network interfaces and prints any radar responses it receives.

```
furuno-server discover
```

This is useful for determining the radar's IP address on an unfamiliar network or verifying that the radar is powered on and reachable. The mode runs until a response is received or the timeout expires.

4 Web Interface

4.1 Starting the Server

The web server starts when the application is launched in `web` mode (see §3.2). By default it listens on port 8080 and serves static files from the `../web` directory relative to the binary. Both values can be overridden with positional arguments. The server starts even if the radar is not reachable, allowing the interface to load and wait for a connection. The `/reconnect` API endpoint triggers a fresh authentication and initialization attempt without restarting the server.

4.2 Page Tour

The web interface consists of four HTML pages, all sharing a common header with navigation links, a consistent CSS stylesheet, and a single shared JavaScript file (`script.js`).

4.2.1 Controls (index.html)

The controls page is the default landing page and provides the most commonly used radar operations. It is divided into two panels. The left panel displays a radar preview image (refreshed every 2 seconds) with a link to the full-screen radar view. The right panel contains quick controls for TX power (on/off), CSV recording (start/stop), range selection (17 scales from 0.0625 to 36 NM), pulse width (S1 through L), manual gain (0–100), and RezBoost level (off/low/medium/high). Each control has an apply button and a refresh button that queries the radar's current state.

Below the quick controls is a pattern loader panel. Users can load a pattern file (`.txt` or `.csv`), set a repeat count (-1 for infinite looping), assign an optional label, and add the pattern to a queue. The queue is displayed as an ordered list, and patterns execute sequentially when the RUN button is pressed. A STOP button halts execution mid-pattern, and RESET clears the queue.

4.2.2 Radar View (radar.html)

The radar view page provides a full-screen PPI display. The primary display element is an HTML5 canvas (1024×1024 pixels) that composites multiple frames of radar data to show target history. Below the canvas are controls for track length (1–50 frames), current frame color, and track history color, with a reset button to restore defaults. An `<img>` element behind the canvas serves as a fallback if canvas rendering is unavailable. The canvas is refreshed every 500 ms by fetching the latest PPI image from the `/newest_png` endpoint.

4.2.3 Settings (settings.html)

The settings page provides granular control over all radar parameters. It is organized into panels grouped by function.

The *connection panel* shows the current connection status and provides reconnect and refresh buttons. A small radar preview image is displayed alongside.

The *power control panel* provides TX on/off buttons and a refresh button to query the current transmitter state.

The *range and pulse panel* allows independent or combined adjustment of range and pulse width, with the same options available on the controls page.

The *gain panel* supports both manual and automatic gain modes. In manual mode, the user sets a value from 0 to 100. In auto mode, a bias offset (0–100) adjusts how aggressively the automatic gain control responds.

The *STC panel* exposes three sensitivity time control zones—near, mid, and far—each with an independent numeric input.

The *signal processing panel* groups main bang suppression (0–255), interference rejection (on/off), bird mode (off/low/medium/high), and Doppler target analysis (off, internal heading, external heading).

The *clutter panel* provides sea clutter (A/C SEA) and rain clutter (A/C RAIN) controls, each with manual and automatic modes. Manual mode sets a fixed rejection level; auto mode adjusts a bias for the radar's internal adaptive filter.

The *antenna speed panel* controls rotation speed (auto/low/high) and a high-RPM override toggle.

The *RezBoost and display panel* sets the resolution enhancement level and display parameters including sweep line count and interpolation mode.

The *pattern loader* on this page has the same functionality as the one on the controls page, with the addition of a manual text input option for entering pattern steps directly.

4.2.4 System Status (status.html)

The system status page displays live telemetry from both the radar and the host system, updated every 500 ms.

The *radar connection* panel shows connection status, radar IP, host IP, TX state, and firmware version. The *session* panel shows server uptime, total rotations received, recording state, the current recording directory, and pattern queue status. The *active settings* panel displays a read-only summary of all current radar parameters: range, pulse, gain, RezBoost, antenna speed, Doppler, interference rejection, bird mode, main bang suppression, STC values, and clutter settings.

The *host resources* panels display CPU load (overall and per-core), memory usage, storage usage, network throughput, and CPU temperature. Each metric includes a progress bar and numeric label.

4.3 PPI Display

The PPI (Plan Position Indicator) display renders radar echo data as a top-down circular image with the radar at the center. The server renders each complete antenna rotation into a 640×640 pixel PNG image using the warm-tinted color mapping described in §8.2. The browser fetches the latest image via the `/newest_png` endpoint.

On the radar view page, the JavaScript composites multiple frames onto an HTML5 canvas to show

target motion history. The *track length* slider controls how many previous frames are retained (1–50). The *current color* picker tints the most recent frame, and the *track color* picker tints older frames. Older frames are drawn with decreasing opacity to produce a fading trail effect. This compositing runs entirely in the browser; the server delivers only single-frame PNG images.

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